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# 'Siempre Sigue Adelante': California Must Protect the Families Who Keep This State Running

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By Latino leaders across California

California is the fourth-largest economy in the world. We are home to Hollywood stars, tech billionaires, and breathtaking landscapes. We are also home to places like Orange Grove and Firebaugh, where the median income is under $40,000. More than 7 million Californians—over a quarter of the state's population—live in or near poverty, according to the Public Policy Institute of California (PPIC). That's more than the combined population of our four largest cities.

Now, facing a $27 billion budget deficit, our state leaders are considering deep and painful cuts to the very programs that hold our fragile safety net together—risking even more families falling into poverty. Governor Gavin Newsom's May Revise proposes freezing Medi-Cal enrollment for those who don't qualify for federal programs, eliminating In-Home Supportive Services (IHSS) for undocumented adults, and removing access to long-term care and dental benefits. These proposals are a direct threat to the health, dignity, and stability of working families.

California is not in a budget crisis. We are at a moral crossroads.

According to PPIC, the estimated median household net worth in California is $288,000. But those near the top hold over $1.3 million in assets—more than 100 times that of those who are at the bottom with a net worth of just $12,000. Latino and Black families make up 41% of all households in California, but represent 55% of those in the bottom quarter of the wealth distribution.

It is Latino families, especially, who stand to lose the most under the Governor's proposal. According to the UCLA Latino Policy and Politics Institute, Latinos make up 52% of all Medi-Cal enrollees in the state. Among Latino beneficiaries, 38% are children under age 18. The median age of Latino enrollees is just 25, compared to 49 for white enrollees. This means cuts to Medi-Cal will hit our youth—and our future—the hardest. Medi-Cal covers nearly 40% of all births in the state.

The California Budget & Policy Center reports that undocumented Californians—many of whom are essential workers—contribute $8.5 billion in state and local taxes annually. Yet this budget proposes denying them access to critical services, including long-term care, dental benefits, and IHSS. These are the same workers who stood by us through the pandemic.

IHSS cuts would devastate home care workers—largely immigrant women—who already face low wages and unstable hours. Slashing overtime pay and travel reimbursements doesn't just hurt these workers, it leaves elderly and disabled Californians without the care they rely on to survive.

Budgets are moral documents. They reflect what we value—and who we value.

Our Latina moms raised us with the phrase "siempre sigue adelante"—always go forward. Those three words capture the never-give-up attitude of our immigrant mothers. It's a worldview rooted in perseverance, mutual care, and refusing to leave others behind. These values must guide our budget decisions, too.

In 2023, 62% of California mothers were in the workforce. That same year, the median income for working mothers was $56,000—$17,000 less than that of working fathers. For Latina moms, the median income was just $40,000, compared to $51,000 for Latino fathers. And still, they carry the weight of caregiving, work, and community.

Latino families are woven into every corner of California life. We are teachers, nurses, farmworkers, entrepreneurs, students, and more. We are the people who make California golden. We don't abandon our siblings or elders in times of need and we ask the same of our state leaders.

We urge Governor Newsom, Senate Budget Chair Scott Wiener, Assembly Budget Chair Jesse Gabriel, and the entire Legislature to chart a different path. Reverse these devastating cuts. Protect Medi-Cal access for all Californians. Invest in our workers, our caregivers, and our children.

This is a defining moment. Let's honor the values that built our state—and go forward, together.

Siempre sigue adelante.

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This op-ed was written by a coalition of Latino leaders from across California's nonprofit, labor, health, and advocacy sectors:

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